WOMEN

In the age of sail the need of hundreds of young men crowded on ships to find sexual relief once in harbor was widely—though not universally—accepted by their officers. Port towns were notorious sites of debauchery and it is no surprise that venereal diseases were commonplace in all navies. When captains were reluctant to let men ashore for fear of desertion, they frequently allowed women to come on board while in port. Officially tolerated as "wives," sometimes hundreds would be accommodated on a warship's gun deck at one time. In the absence of privacy, this lead to scenes that shocked more religious consciences.



PORT OF PLEASURE The expansion of London's maritime trade during the 18th century, and the presence of two Royal Navy dockyards, created an increasing demand for prostitution in the capital.

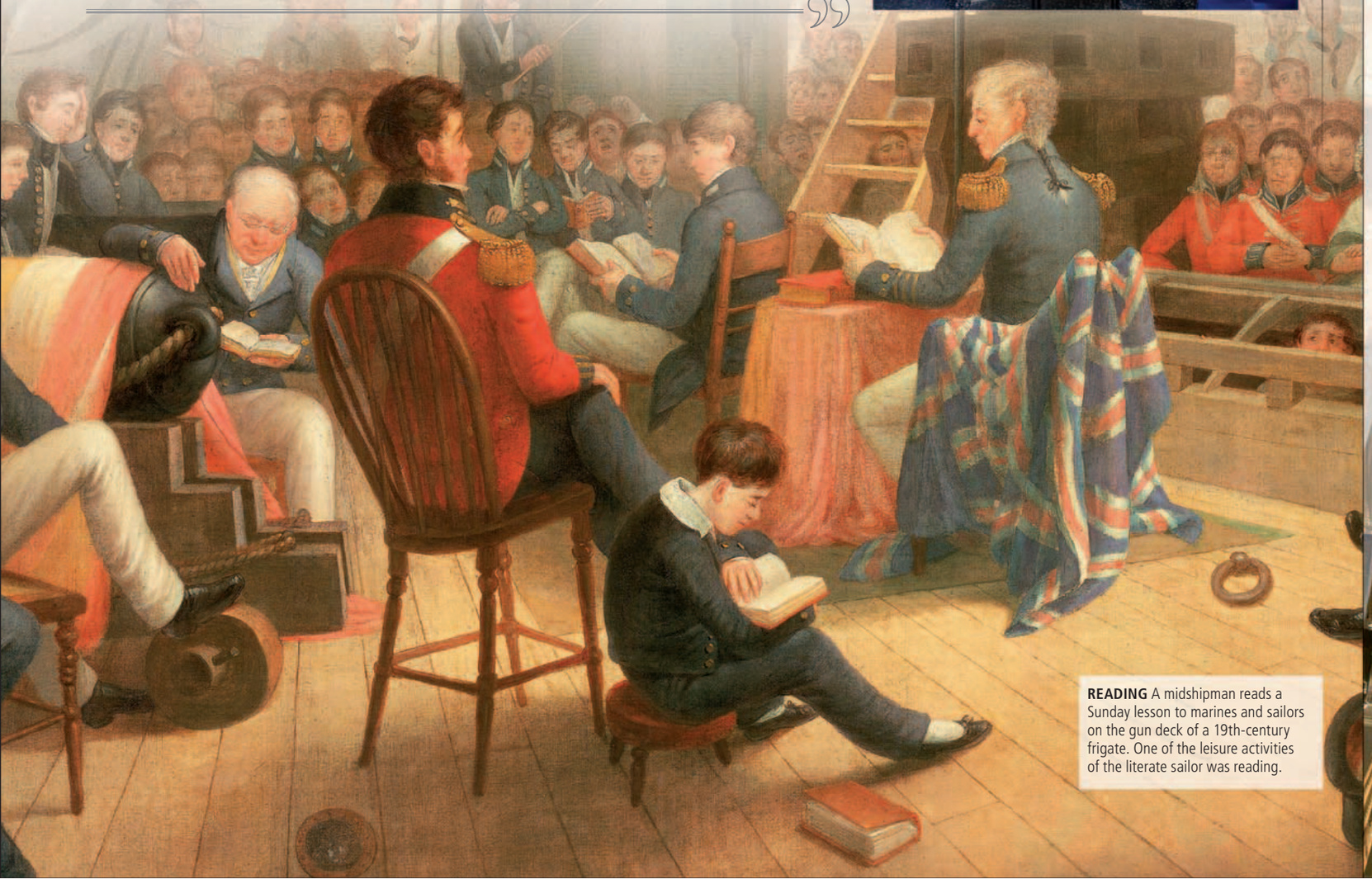
MODERN TIMES

In the 20th century the maritime authorities made increasing efforts to regulate leisure activities. They encouraged more salubrious games by organizing official competitions—racing ship's boats was a favorite of the pre-World War I Royal Navy. The US Navy tried to clean up its act by, for example, banning all alcohol consumption on ships along with indecent tattoos—an edict that sent many sailors scurrying to tattoo parlors to "dress up" their naked ladies. During World War II the ban on alcohol was subverted on some US ships by the operation of illegal stills, refining alcohol from various cleaning substances or fuels. Gambling also flourished unchecked by official disapproval. Radios and record players replaced group singing, while increasing literacy made reading a favorite pastime.

SHIP'S LOUNGE This lounge room on the American destroyer USS *Donald Cook* combines a dining area with a plasma TV, a DVD player, and easy chairs.



> *Many a man of war hath been her willing prisoner, and paid a proper ransom . . . [she] loves to fight yard arm . . . and be briskly boarded.*
>
> **HARRIS'S LIST OF LONDON LADIES (1758)**, John Harris's popular list of ladies was updated annually until the 1790s



READING A midshipman reads a Sunday lesson to marines and sailors on the gun deck of a 19th-century frigate. One of the leisure activities of the literate sailor was reading.